

Max and Leo and the Big Red X Adventure

Little adventurers • 3-4 years old



Max and Leo were almost four. They were best friends. They liked the same things: big puddles, tiny bugs, and silly jokes.

One sunny morning, Max came to Leo's door with a very important face.

"I made a map," Max said.

"A map?" Leo's eyes got round.

Max held up a paper. It had thick crayon lines. It had stars and arrows. It had a big red X.

Leo giggled. "It looks like a spaghetti road."

"It is a brave road," Max said. "Do you want an adventure?"

Leo nodded fast. "Yes, please!"

They put on their shoes. Max wore his blue hat. Leo wore his yellow socks with little ducks. They felt ready for anything.

Max pointed to the first picture on the map. It showed a circle with spikes.

"That's the prickly bush," Max said. "It is the first stop."

They walked down the hallway like it was a long jungle path. They stepped over a toy car. They stepped around a cushion mountain.

Leo whispered, "Quiet feet."

Max whispered back, "Brave feet."

They reached the garden. The prickly bush sat by the fence, green and poky, but not scary.

Leo held his hands behind his back. "We don't touch. We look."

Max nodded. "Good thinking."

On the map, Max drew a little smile by the bush. "We did it," he said.

The next picture showed wavy blue lines.

"That's the river," Leo said.

"The river is the laundry basket," Max said, very serious.

They went inside. The laundry basket was full of warm clothes. It smelled like soap and cuddles.

"How do we cross the river?" Leo asked.

Max looked around. He did not rush. He used his thinking eyes.

"We need a bridge," he said.

Leo saw a small stool. "Bridge!" he said.

Together, they pushed the stool close. It made a soft scoot sound on the floor. Max tried first, one foot, then the other. He balanced like a tightrope walker.

"I am a wobbly crab," Max said.

Leo laughed. "I am a steady turtle."

They crossed, one at a time, very careful. No one fell. The river was crossed.

Max put a sticker on the map. A shiny star. "Star for smart," he said.

The next picture was a tall square with dots.

“That’s the tower,” Leo said.

“The tower is the bookshelf,” Max said.

The bookshelf was tall, but friendly. It held picture books and a soft bear wearing glasses.

At the top shelf was the treasure they wanted. It was a small box of raisins and two shiny apples.

Leo looked up. “It’s too high.”

Max took a deep breath. “We can do it safely.”

They looked for help. Not a big help, just the right help.

“Mom!” Max called.

Mom came with a calm smile. “What are my explorers doing?”

“We are on a map mission,” Leo said. “We need the treasure.”

Mom read the map like it was a real pirate map. “Ah yes. The Big Red X.”

She brought a chair and put it near the shelf. “You may climb with me right here.”

Max climbed slowly. Mom’s hand stayed close. Leo watched and cheered softly.

“You are brave, Max,” Leo said.

Max reached the treasure box. He held it like it was gold. Then he climbed down, slow and safe.

They shared the raisins right away. Max ate one. Leo ate one.

"These are crunchy jewels," Leo said.

Max smiled. "Jewels for good helpers."

They went back to the map. The last picture showed a round shape with lines.

"That's the sun," Leo said.

"No," Max said, grinning. "That's the yellow blanket on the couch."

They walked to the couch. The yellow blanket was warm and bright, like a little sun you could hug.

Under the blanket was the Big Red X spot. Max lifted the corner carefully.

There was a surprise. It was not a scary surprise. It was a funny surprise.

It was Max's toy dinosaur, wearing Leo's duck sock on its head.

Leo burst into giggles. "He is Duck-o-saurus!"

Max laughed too. "He guarded the treasure!"

They put the dinosaur in the middle. They put the apples beside it. They made a tiny picnic.

Mom sat with them for a minute. "I like your adventure," she said. "You used your brains and your kind hands."

Leo looked at the map. "We went far," he said.

Max pointed to the hallway. "We went to the bush jungle, the laundry river, the book tower, and the blanket sun."

Leo leaned close. "Next time, we can make a map to somewhere new."

“Somewhere new and somewhere safe,” Max said.

They ate their apple slices. They listened to the quiet house sounds. A clock ticked. A bird chirped outside.

Max folded the map carefully. “Maps help us remember,” he said.

Leo patted the paper. “And maps help us share.”

Max nodded. “Sharing is brave too.”

They curled under the yellow blanket, warm as toast. The adventure was done, but it stayed in their smiles.

In the calm, bright room, Max whispered, “Good night, explorers.”

Leo whispered back, “Good night, brave feet.”

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Who are the two best friends in the story?

- Max and Leo
- Tom and Tim
- Sam and Ben
- Anna and Mia

2) What did they use as the river?

- The laundry basket
- A pillow
- A toy car
- A book

3) Who helped them get the treasure from the tall shelf?

- Mom
- Dad
- Their friend
- The teacher

4) What was under the yellow blanket at the Big Red X?

- A toy dinosaur
- A cookie
- A red ball
- A picture book

Correct answers:

1) Max and Leo 2) The laundry basket 3) Mom 4) A toy dinosaur

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Important face: A look that shows something matters a lot to someone.

Prickly bush: A plant with sharp bits that can poke your skin if you touch it.

Cushion mountain: A big pile of soft cushions that looks like a tall hill to climb.

Laundry basket: A container that holds dirty or clean clothes before folding or washing.

Tightrope walker: A person who walks very carefully on a thin line high above the ground.

Bookshelf: A piece of furniture with shelves where storybooks sit.

Treasure: Something special and valuable you are excited to find and keep.

Raisins: Small, sweet dried grapes that are chewy and make a nice snack.

Yellow blanket: A warm, soft cover that is yellow and good for snuggling.

Adventure: A fun and slightly exciting trip where you try new things.

Bridge: A thing you use to cross from one side to the other safely.